# If I Could Paint the Rain

## By Rosary O'Neill

## INTRODUCTION

*ACTRESS:* *Rooster Dubonnet is a French artist coming to grips with his last days fighting cancer. The end is near. He knows this.*
*ACTOR:* *I just want to be left alone, and not be pestered by a new nurse – Ms. Falcon*
*ACTRESS:* *Nurse Falcon isn't the type to give in. But can she connect with him in time?*
*TOGETHER:* *If I Could Paint the Rain by Rosary O'Neill*

*The dayroom of a Garden District mansion, New Orleans, Louisiana. Rooster Dubonnet, a young man, twenties, dark-haired, gaunt, almost emaciated, lies in bed in silk pajamas. A painter who has pushed himself beyond reasonable limits. He is critically ill from cancer. The disease gives him a distinct nonchalance, the charm of the damned. If he were not so sick and pasty-looking, he could be handsome with strong features, thick hair, and broad shoulders. Even so, there are kindness and nobility in his face.*

**ROOSTER:** I'm cold. Maybe the rain makes me that way. It's full of emptiness. Cold blue in the morning, bright blue at noon and intense Italianate blue in the late afternoon. The walls soak up the rain. There is vermilion in the shadows, violet in the gray. Like the sound of everything that's there, that I try to paint. When you are inside the rain, there's luminosity. I want images that have the density of rain. Nature does it easily. When you try to copy it, it's gone. Rain's not easily captured. It's the pink lie, the last little thing that crawled out of Pandora's box with all her colors. If I could paint rain the way it is, thick and smelling of oak leaves, I could figure life out.

*(Rooster closes his eyes. Monica Falcon, a stunning nurse, twenties, arrives. Delicate features match her gentleness: fine skin, graceful hands, hair that tumbles about her face. She is dressed simply but impeccably and holds a satchel under her arm. She pauses at the doorway, removing her cape and looking about in the house.)*

**MONICA:** Hello, hello ... anyone there? I'm Monica Falcon, the new nurse.

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**ROOSTER:** What? *(Calls out.)* Ma.

**MONICA:** *(Puts thermometer in his mouth.)* Are you in pain?

**ROOSTER:** No. *(He pulls out the thermometer, leans to an intercom)*

**MONICA:** You sounded as if you were in pain.

**ROOSTER:** *(Into the intercom)* Ma, pick up.

**MONICA:** Everyone's gone.

**ROOSTER:** Unlikely. *(Into the intercom)* Pick up, I said.

**MONICA:** The house echoes quiet.

**ROOSTER:** *(Into the intercom)* Ma. They sent a woman.

**MONICA:** You've a wonderful house ...

**ROOSTER:** *(Into the intercom)* I asked for a male nurse.

**MONICA:** It's like a hotel.

**ROOSTER:** *(Into the intercom)* You're not my guest. I'm not lying about halfdressed with a woman. *(Monica checks about for lights.)*

**ROOSTER:** Don't.

**MONICA:** Do you live in darkness?

**ROOSTER:** Best way to survive in the Garden District.

**MONICA:** *(Looks at her feet.)* These shoes looked good before I walked through water.

**ROOSTER:** Click your heels and go back to OZ.

**MONICA:** We can catch the last rays of the sun.

**ROOSTER:** You're not staying. *(He sits up, reaches for his robe, but is still weak and has to breathe a few moments. She looks out the window. He reaches for the phone.)*

**MONICA:** The light feels good. Cold bracing sunshine, right behind the rain. That'll keep you awake.

**ROOSTER:** *(Into the receiver.)* Is this the Parker Agency?

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**MONICA:** I love a bright afternoon sky.

**ROOSTER:** This is Rooster Dubonnet. I requested a male nurse.

**MONICA:** *(Reaches for the phone.)* Give me that.

**ROOSTER:** *(Stretches phone away, panting, talks into it)* I'm not paying for this woman.

**MONICA:** What do you have against women?

**ROOSTER:** *(Into the phone.)* I was nice to those rejects you sent. She can't be the only nurse who'll come.

**MONICA:** *(Takes out a blood pressure kit.)* I'll take your blood pressure.

**ROOSTER:** *(Into the phone.)* You said you had 200 nurses. *(Into the phone.)* I don't want this woman. *(Into the phone.)* Tell her to leave.

**MONICA:** *(Takes phone, speaks into it)* Everybody's fine. *(Hangs up. To Rooster)* One, two, three ... up. *(Rooster sits up, very weak, wraps his robe limply over his silk pajamas.)*

**ROOSTER:** Stay away. I'm warning you.

**MONICA:** Let me help you to that chair.

**ROOSTER:** I'm calling the police. *(He reaches for the phone, but she grabs it and puts it in her pocket.)*

**MONICA:** I'll change those sheets. *(He stumbles to his feet. He is panting for breath, totters, and grasps onto furniture. He stops for a second. She watches him from the corner o/her eyes and goes to make the bed.)*

**MONICA:** You can do it?

**ROOSTER:** I can do it. *(He presses a hand alarm, which blares. They struggle for the alarm. She pushes it off)*

**MONICA:** What's that? Turn it off.

**ROOSTER:** Not likely.

**MONICA:** Give it over.

**ROOSTER:** No.

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**MONICA:** *(Pulls alarm from his fist.)* You think you can get rid of me?

**ROOSTER:** You're the roughest ...

**MONICA:** My landlord's evicted me.

**ROOSTER:** Toughest ...

**MONICA:** Called me at five AM.

**ROOSTER:** This is not a hotel.

**MONICA:** I've no friends or relatives here.

**ROOSTER:** That's the first good news about you.

**MONICA:** I'd like to help. *(He walks, but stumbles. She calls out as he moves cautiously along.)* Take my arm!

**ROOSTER:** I'm not some bag you can carry around.

**MONICA:** Can you get to that door?

**ROOSTER:** Uh-huh. If I push myself I can. *(He walks carefully. Reaching the door, he rests his head back, then turns and sets off a strobe light siren. She runs over. They struggle for it.)*

**MONICA:** You crazy ...

**ROOSTER:** You want to hear the sound of a siren ...

**MONICA:** Out of my way!

**ROOSTER:** I'm weak, but I can do it.

**MONICA:** Stop. Nobody's going to bail me out. *(She turns the siren off He staggers to a chair and leans over the back, coughing.)* Have you had anything to eat? Or drink?

**ROOSTER:** Not today.

**MONICA:** *(Hands him glass.)* Take a few sips.

**ROOSTER:** No, thanks. Have you ever heard of the nurse who poisons the emperor? This emperor so feared assassination, he only ate ripe figs from a tree.

**MONICA:** Drink.

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**ROOSTER:** In the night, his nurse injected them with poison.

**MONICA:** Just ...

**ROOSTER:** I n the morning, the emperor ate one and died. *(He drinks a little, then pours water on a plant. She speaks continuously, overlapping him.)*

**MONICA:** Since you won't let me help you, may I ask you some questions?

**ROOSTER:** What's that?

**MONICA:** I'm studying astrology ... on the side.

**ROOSTER:** It's amateur night in Dixie.

**MONICA:** I looked you up. You've got a tenth house, Pluto in Leo.

**ROOSTER:** Fortune-tellers. They're everything I'm running from –

**MONICA:** Which means you're gifted ...

**ROOSTER:** *(Breathing fast.)* The whole spectre of charlatans –

**MONICA:** At being able to ...

**ROOSTER:** That haunt artists' history.

**MONICA:** Translate archetypal energy ...

**ROOSTER:** I'm three times more likely to die from the flu ...

**MONICA:** Through the power of the personal image ...

**ROOSTER:** Than to speak to a student astrologer. Y' all are the psychos of the science profession.

**MONICA:** Think you can get in that chair?

**ROOSTER:** Uh-huh. If I'm careful, I can.

**MONICA:** I know you're a famous artist from a well-to-do family ...

**ROOSTER:** Why do people pursue me?

**MONICA:** May I ask you some questions? It would make my job easier.

**ROOSTER:** You haven't a job with me.

**MONICA:** You're so ...

**ROOSTER:** Difficult? Some artists don't do interviews, and thank God they don't do

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them. I don't want to be the entertainment.

**MONICA:** And you're not. *(Rooster rises with effort, crosses to the birdcage, whistles "Dixie."]*

**ROOSTER:** My parrot, Commander Butler, just flew in.

**MONICA:** Where?

**ROOSTER:** He died but sometimes he visits. He's my very special house ghost. The two things Butler does best are scream, "Where's the maid?" and whistle, "Dixie." Calling the maid is so passe. *(Pause)* You think I'm crazy.

**MONICA:** No. What's your diagnosis?

**ROOSTER:** I belong to the National Caged Bird Society ...

**MONICA:** Your symptoms?

**ROOSTER:** But I couldn't make that bird talk.

**MONICA:** How long have ...

**ROOSTER:** Butler's a Southerner from French aristocrats ...

**MONICA:** You been sick?

**ROOSTER:** He was bred by a gentleman who kept his plantation up river. One difference between Butler and me. He's dead and I'm alive. But I'll be flying off soon. *(Pause)* Are you from the South?

**MONICA:** Delaware.

**ROOSTER:** Y'all like to eat on paper plates in halls covered with graffiti. What do you have going for you? That's what I want to know.

**MONICA:** My husband was from Jackson.

**ROOSTER:** There's a touch of Mississippi in your family? What does Mr. Falcon do without you?

**MONICA:** My . . .I . . .. Oh Lord . . . . . I mustn't let ... Where're my Kleenex? . . . . . You think I'd be here if I . . . . . .

**ROOSTER:** Take my handkerchief. *(She does.)* Don't start the sadness machine.

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**MONICA:** It happens frequently. I'm so tired, and broke. It's not professional. I don't want to be so emotional. Your bed is ready. *(Rain pours around the sides of the room. She removes the thermometer, writes something on her chart. He pulls a sketchpad from behind a seat.)*

**ROOSTER:** I've not stopped painting because I wanted to. This morning I said to myself, I'm going to paint, if my energy holds out ... Soon as it's warm and the sun's shining ...

**MONICA:** Well? *(Rain begins whistling around. He rubs the armrests)*

**ROOSTER:** My energy didn't hold out ... Listen to that rain blowing round outside.

**MONICA:** It sounds neighborly.

**ROOSTER:** Coming right through the sun.

**MONICA:** I love to hear it when I'm inside.

**ROOSTER:** Oh, but it's cold walking into the rain when you have to. *(Begins to shiver.)* Look at me shake, will you? The thought of rain and I start to shiver.

**MONICA:** Try to nap. Would you like another blanket? *(He lies back slowly. She covers him.)*

**ROOSTER:** That does feel good.

**MONICA:** I told you. *(He has closed his eyes and gone to sleep. Monica watches over him as the lights are brought down. The lights come up.)*

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Rosary O'Neill***
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## AWARD HISTORY

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